

JAINISM AND BUDDHISM

CORE FIRST | SOURCE-CONTROLLED | UPSC AT-A-GLANCE

Early doctrine != later system != redaction != material evidence

1. SOURCE, LAYER AND DATE CONTROL

- Early teachings survive through orally transmitted, school-specific and later redacted corpora.
- Separate founder horizon, composition, recitation, redaction, manuscript and archaeology.
- Traditional dates for Mahavira and Buddha differ; use sixth-fifth centuries BCE unless the tradition is named.
- Text proves remembered doctrine or discipline; inscription and archaeology test institutions, donors and sites.

TERM -> EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM -> LIMIT

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2. SETTING AND THE SHRAMANA FIELD

- Agrarian expansion + towns + routes + states + social differentiation widened audiences and patronage.
- Shramana included Jain, Buddhist, Ajivika, materialist and other renunciant positions.
- Ritual cost, hierarchy and violence mattered, but no urban, merchant, iron or varna monocause is sufficient.
- Brahmanical and shramana currents debated, competed, borrowed and later accommodated one another.

TERM -> EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM -> LIMIT

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3. JAIN ANTECEDENTS AND MAHAVIRA

- Jain tradition: 24 Tirthankaras; Rishabhnanatha 1st, Parshvanatha 23rd, Mahavira 24th.
- Parshva may preserve an earlier ascetic stratum; remote Tirthankara dates remain sacred tradition, not secure history.
- Mahavira/Vardhamana/Nigantha Nataputta: renunciation -> austerity -> kevala knowledge -> teaching community.
- Four-vow/ five-vow distinction is traditional; biography and chronology vary across sectarian memories.

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4. JAIN REALITY, KARMA AND RELEASE

- Jiva is conscious and enduring; ajiva includes matter, motion/rest media, space and time.
- Activity and passion -> asrava (influx) -> bandha (bondage).
- Samvara stops new influx; nirjara sheds accumulated karmic matter; moksha perfects the individual jiva.
- Dharma-dravya and adharma-dravya are cosmological media, not simply moral good and evil.

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5. JAIN PATH, ETHICS AND MANY-SIDEDNESS

- Tiriratna: right faith, right knowledge, right conduct.
- Five vows: ahimsa, satya, asteya, brahmacharya, aparigraha.
- Mahavratas for ascetics; anuvratas and supplementary restraints for laity.
- Anekantavada = many-sided reality; nayavada = standpoints; syadvada = conditioned predication; mature system is later.

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6. JAIN COMMUNITY, CANON, SECTS AND CONTINUITY

- Fourfold community: monks, nuns, laymen and laywomen; household support sustains renunciation.
- Pataliputra preservation and Valabhi redaction are later tradition-specific accounts.
- Digambara-Svetambara division developed gradually: clothing, canon, images/practice and women's liberation differ.
- Mathura, Udayagiri-Khandagiri, western India and Karnataka show regional patronage; Jainism changed while enduring.

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7. BUDDHA: BIOGRAPHY AND DATING

- Siddhartha Gautama, a Sakya, is remembered through four sights, renunciation and search among teachers.
- Extreme austerity rejected -> awakening at Bodhi Gaya -> first sermon at Sarnath -> teaching career.
- Mahaparinibbana at Kushinagara; Lumbini pillar gives early epigraphic support to birthplace memory.
- Long and short chronologies differ; sacred biography is not a contemporary diary.

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8. BUDDHIST DIAGNOSIS AND MIDDLE PATH

- Four Noble Truths: dukkha, origin, cessation and path.
- Middle Way rejects sensual indulgence and self-mortification.
- Eightfold Path: view, intention, speech, action, livelihood, effort, mindfulness and concentration.
- Wisdom + ethical conduct + mental discipline form an integrated practice, not a mechanical staircase.

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9. CONDITIONALITY, NO-SELF AND NIRVANA

- Dependent origination: conditioned arising and cessation; not fate, first cause or a permanent substance.
- Anicca = impermanence; anatta = no permanent independent self; dukkha = conditioned unsatisfactoriness.
- Five aggregates analyse the person; intentional karma sustains rebirth without an eternal soul.
- Nirvana ends greed, hatred, delusion and the rebirth process; it is not mere death or nihilism.

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10. SANGHA, VINAYA, LAITY AND WOMEN

- Bhikkhu/bhikkhuni communities operate through Vinaya; upasaka/upasika provide food, robes, medicine and residence.
- Lay-monastic reciprocity links merit, teaching, routes, towns and agrarian support.
- Mahapajapati Gotami tradition and Therigatha attest women's agency; garudhamma transmission is layered and debated.
- Access widened beyond hereditary ritual privilege, yet caste, obligation and patriarchy did not vanish.

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11. COUNCILS, CANONS AND EARLY SCHOOLS

- Rajagriha, Vaishali and Pataliputra councils are conventional, school-specific institutional memories.
- No single pan-Buddhist fourth council: Kanishka-Kashmir and Sri Lankan writing-down traditions differ.
- Theravada Pali Tipitaka = Vinaya, Sutta, Abhidhamma; other schools preserved Vinayas, Agamas and Abhidharma.
- Sthavira and Mahasanghika lineages are complex; Theravada is not every Sthavira school and not 'Hinayana'.

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12. MAHAYANA, EMPTINESS AND VAJRAYANA

- Mahayana emerged gradually around the early centuries BCE/CE through diverse texts and communities.
- Bodhisattva ideal and paramitas widen the salvific horizon; Maitreya is the future Buddha, not exclusively Mahayana.
- Madhyamaka uses emptiness/dependent designation; emptiness is not non-existence.
- Vajrayana's mantra, mandala, deity yoga and tantric texts are later first-millennium developments.

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13. PATRONAGE, SPREAD, MONASTERIES AND ART

- Ashoka's inscriptions support Buddhist patronage and sangha concern; dhamma is broader than Buddhist doctrine.
- Kanishka matters to north-western networks, but council and conversion details are later traditions.
- Rulers + merchants + artisans + women + monks/nuns + local donors sustained routes, monasteries and education.
- Stupa, chaitya and vihara; Sanchi, Bharhut, Amaravati, Karle, Ajanta, Nalanda and Gandhara require phase-specific dating.

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14. COMPARISON, DECLINE AND EXAM VERDICT

- Jainism: enduring jiva, material karma, rigorous ahimsa; Buddhism: anatta, intentional karma, Middle Path.
- Both formed renunciant-lay communities and questioned exclusive ritual authority, but neither was uniformly egalitarian.
- Buddhist contraction in India was regional and multicausal; Himalayan/eastern survival, Asian expansion and revival matter.
- Answer route: context -> doctrine -> institution -> patronage/material evidence -> variation -> qualified verdict.

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VERDICT: shared shramana ecology; distinct doctrines, institutions and historical trajectories.